Omar Mohammad Solitario Ali

Omar Mohammad Solitario Ali (c. 1950s, Marawi City — April 8, 2022, Cagayan de Oro) was one of the most consequential figures in the modern history of Maranao political leadership. A former commander of the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF), two-term Mayor of Marawi City, federalism advocate, government peace emissary, and counter-extremism campaigner, he lived a life that traced the entire arc of the Bangsamoro struggle, from jungle insurgency to institutional governance.

His name, "Solitario" (The Solitary One), wasn't just a moniker. It described how he lived his convictions: often standing alone, often misunderstood, but never veering from what he believed was right for his people and for Islam. He is remembered today as the man who gave birth to the concept of "Moral Governance" in Marawi City, a framework that continues to shape how the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) imagines the relationship between Islamic ethics and modern public administration.

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Background and Lineage

To understand Omar Ali, you have to understand the Maranao world he came from. The Lanao provinces are governed by one of the oldest and most structured traditional political systems in the Philippines: the Pat a Pangampong sa Ranao, or the four principalities of Masiu, Unayan, Balo-i, and Bayabao.<ref name="familysearch">Lanao del Sur Province, Philippines Genealogy. FamilySearch. Accessed March 17, 2026. https://www.familysearch.org/en/wiki/Lanao_del_Sur_Province,_Philippines_Genealogy</ref> In this world, political power has always followed lineage, and lineage is validated by an unwritten but deeply felt code called *Igma Ago Taritib* (Order and Consensus).<ref name="familysearch" />

Ali was born into a family that sat at a high point within this traditional hierarchy. His connections, both through his father and his mother, tied him to original datuships in Marawi.<ref name="mindanews2022a">PAGDARO SA KALINAW: Dureza's Betrayal and Duterte's Hypocrisy in Marawi. MindaNews. Accessed March 17, 2026. https://mindanews.com/mindaviews/2017/09/pagdaro-sa-kalinaw-durezas-betrayal-and-dutertes-hypocrisy-in-marawi/</ref> The move to carry his mother's surname, "Ali," rather than his father's "Salic" (the name used by his half-brother, Fahad "Pre" Salic) was deliberate and strategic. He adopted "Ali" as both his revolutionary identity and his political brand, connecting him directly to the clans of Marawi and Baloi, and specifically to the datuships of Guimba and Buadi Sacayo.<ref name="mindanews2022a" />

This wasn't just a name change. It was a political statement, one that allowed him to command loyalty across multiple sub-clans and to speak with authority not just as one man but as the embodiment of an entire kinship network.

Central to that network was the concept of *maratabat*: the Maranao ethos of honor, rank, and the preservation of family prestige. For the Ali-Salic family, maratabat was the engine behind their dominance of the Marawi executive office for nearly two decades. During the 2016 elections, Maguindanaon datus with Maranaw ancestry crossed provincial borders to campaign for the family, a demonstration that their influence had never been limited by administrative lines but was rooted in a centuries-old genealogical bond.<ref name="philstar2016b">Maguindanaon datus back Lanao del Sur gubernatorial bet. Philstar.com. April 7, 2016. https://www.philstar.com/nation/2016/04/07/1570412/maguindanaon-datus-back-lanao-del-sur-gubernatorial-bet</ref>

The Revolutionary Years: MNLF and the Birth of "Solitario"

Omar Ali came of age during the most violent chapter of modern Moro history. The Jabidah Massacre of 1968 and the declaration of Martial Law by Ferdinand Marcos in 1972 sent a generation of Moro youth into the hills.<ref name="academiadoc">DEMOCRACY AT GUNPOINT: Election-related Violence in the Philippines. Academia.edu. Accessed March 17, 2026. https://www.academia.edu/33693019/DEMOCRACY_AT_GUNPOINT_Election_related_Violence_in_the_Philippines_</ref> The Moro National Liberation Front, founded by Nur Misuari, became the vehicle for a people who had decided that they would no longer wait for justice to arrive through institutions that had never treated them as equals.<ref name="academiadoc" />

Ali joined the MNLF and rose to become a commander in the Lanao sector. In the jungle, he earned the name "Solitario" because he was precisely that: a fighter who could hold the line alone, who kept his cool when others panicked, and whose loyalty to the cause never wavered even when it cost him everything.<ref name="mindanews2022a" /> He was part of the revolutionary vanguard that ultimately forced the Philippine government to the negotiating table, a process that led to the 1976 Tripoli Agreement, which specifically named Lanao del Sur and Marawi City as central to the proposed autonomous region.<ref name="pcid">VIOLENCE IN POLITICS AND THE POLITICS OF VIOLENCE. Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy. Accessed March 17, 2026. https://www.pcid.com.ph/wp-content/uploads/2017/03/Violence-in-Politics.pdf</ref>

More than a military period, the revolutionary years gave Ali something most politicians can never buy: what his colleagues would later call "revolutionary legitimacy." He wasn't just a datu who got elected. He was an "elder brother of the struggle," a title that carried genuine moral weight in Maranao society.<ref name="mindanews2022b">BANGSAMORO SPEAKS: On the Marawi Siege and the people unjustly implicated. MindaNews. April 2022. https://mindanews.com/mindaviews/2022/04/bangsamoro-speaks-on-the-marawi-siege-and-the-people-unjustly-implicated/</ref> When the 1996 Final Peace Agreement was signed, Ali was among those who crossed from the jungle into the government, joining fellow MNLF leaders like Gerry Salapuddin in the work of translating military influence into something that could actually govern a people.<ref name="academiadoc" />

Education and Intellectual Formation

What separated Omar Ali from many of his contemporaries was his refusal to let the revolution be his only credential. He pursued formal education with the same seriousness he brought to the battlefield.

He completed his studies in law, which gave him the language and tools to challenge the state within its own framework, something he would do repeatedly in the final years of his life when defending himself and his family against criminal accusations.<ref name="mindanews2022b" /> He argued for due process in an environment that often relied on what he bluntly called "raw intelligence," and he knew enough about the law to name exactly what was being violated.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

He also earned a **Master in Development Management (MDM)** from the Asian Institute of Management (AIM), an institution known for training public and private sector leaders across Asia.<ref name="mindanews2022b" /> His time at AIM fundamentally changed how he saw Marawi City, not just as a religious center or a symbol of Moro resistance, but as a city that could plan for itself, attract investment, and manage its own socioeconomic development with competence and confidence.<ref name="philstar2016a">Ex-Marawi mayor to focus on preserving local cultures, arts. Philstar.com. April 1, 2016. https://www.philstar.com/nation/2016/04/01/1568318/ex-marawi-mayor-focus-preserving-local-cultures-arts</ref>

Alongside his legal and managerial training, Ali held the rank of Major in the Reserved Command of the Philippine Army. It was a rank that puzzled many outsiders: why would a former rebel hold a commission in the national military? For Ali, it was a deliberate statement of philosophy. A Moro leader could work within the state without surrendering to it.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

Mayoral Tenure (2001–2007): Building Moral Governance

Omar Ali served two terms as Mayor of Marawi City, from 2001 to 2007. The era is still talked about in the city today, and not always quietly.

The Moral Governance Framework

His entire approach to running Marawi was built on a single conviction: that a city's administration should reflect the values of its people, and that for a majority-Muslim city, those values were Islamic. He called it "Moral Governance," and he meant it literally.

Under his administration, gambling was banned outright. Video karera machines were destroyed. Billiard halls were shut down. The distribution of alcohol and pornography was prohibited.<ref name="philstar2006">Marawi City cracks down on criminality. Philstar.com. April 1, 2006. https://www.philstar.com/nation/2006/04/01/329222/marawi-city-cracks-down-criminality</ref> These weren't symbolic moves. They were enforced.

He also implemented dress codes and ordinances regulating public conduct, including strict rules on the public behavior of men who dressed or presented as women, and guidelines on modest attire for Muslim women.<ref name="philstar2006" /> Human rights organizations outside Marawi raised concerns about some of these policies. Inside the city, many residents saw them as an honest effort to preserve what Marawi was, against what they felt it was slowly being pressured to become.

Development, Tourism, and Rido Resolution

Ali wasn't only interested in moral enforcement. His AIM training showed up in his push to develop Marawi City as an eco-tourism hub, emphasizing the preservation of Maranaw arts, crafts, and traditions as the city's most sustainable economic asset.<ref name="philstar2016a" /> He frequently invoked the Dansalan Declaration of 1935, the historic appeal of Maranao sultans to the United States for a separate independence, positioning his governance as the living continuation of that centuries-old claim to self-determination.<ref name="philstar2016a" />

He also tackled *rido*, the clan feuds that had long drained Lanao of energy and investment. Using his own standing in the Sultanate system, he personally brokered settlements between families, creating a more stable environment for growth.<ref name="philstar2016a" /> This was governance through relationship, the Maranao way, made effective by the credibility of the man doing it.

Political Evolution: Federalism and the PDP-Laban Years

When Rodrigo Duterte rose to national prominence in 2016, Omar Ali saw an opportunity he couldn't pass up. He became the Regional President of PDP-Laban and played a central role in delivering the Duterte vote in Lanao del Sur.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

His support for Duterte wasn't just political calculation. He genuinely believed in federalism as, in his own words, the "antidote to extremism." The logic was straightforward: when Moro communities can govern themselves, implement Islamic principles in their own territories, and manage their own resources, the recruitment pitches of radical groups lose their power.<ref name="mindanews2022b" /> He had been watching "imperial Manila" run the Muslim south for decades, and he was convinced the model had failed everyone.

He attempted to reclaim the Marawi mayoralty in both 2016 and 2019 but lost both times to Majul Gandamra.<ref name="mindanewsmain">Omar Solitario Ali: "I cannot be and I will not be a terrorist." MindaNews. April 2022. https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2022/04/omar-solitario-ali-i-cannot-be-and-i-will-not-be-a-terrorist/</ref> The electoral defeats stung. But his influence as a unifying voice across the MNLF-MILF divide, and his standing as a "kingmaker" in Lanao politics, remained very much alive.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

The 2017 Marawi Siege: The Emissary in the Crossfire

The most painful and most defining chapter of Omar Ali's life began on May 23, 2017, when the ISIS-inspired Maute group launched the siege that would leave Marawi City in ruins.

Ali's position was uniquely complicated. His half-brother Fahad Salic was related by marriage to the Maute family, a connection made 35 years earlier that had nothing to do with ideology.<ref name="mindanews2022a" /> But in the climate of Martial Law and military intelligence reports, "related to" became "in league with," and Ali found himself caught in a trap he had not built.

The Peace Emissary Role

Months before the siege broke out, Ali had been working as a consultant for the Office of the Presidential Adviser on the Peace Process (OPAPP). He had personally contacted Secretary Jesus Dureza to warn about the growing radicalization of the Maute brothers.<ref name="mindanews2022a" /> He was then sent to Butig to meet with the Maute group directly, using his status as a revolutionary elder to make one last argument for a different path.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

He described those conversations as "very confrontational." He argued with Abdullah Maute directly about the meaning of Islam, about social change, and about where the path they were on would lead.

> "I told them their path leads only to the destruction of Lanao. This is not the Islam we inherited. This is not what our fathers fought for." (Omar Solitario Ali, as recounted in his later interviews)

When the siege finally erupted, Ali was in Cagayan de Oro, meeting with other Moro leaders on containment strategies.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

Arrest Orders, Clearance, and Revocation

Despite his documented role as a government emissary, Ali's name was included in the arrest orders issued under Martial Law.<ref name="mindanewsmain" /> The Department of National Defense alleged links between Ali, his sons (including Vice Mayor Arafat Salic), and the Maute group. Ali rejected these charges entirely, calling the family marriage connection "a coincidence of 35 years ago" that implied no political alignment.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

What followed was a disorienting sequence of bureaucratic reversals:

- **August 16, 2017:** Defense Secretary Delfin Lorenzana issued a "conditional clearance" for Ali and his sons, acting on the representation of Secretary Dureza.<ref name="oppap">Statement of Presidential Peace Adviser on Martial Law

Clearance. peace.gov.ph. August 2017. https://peace.gov.ph/2017/08/statement-presidential-peace-adviser-martial-law-clearance-former-marawi-mayor-omar-solitario/</ref>

- **August 22, 2017:** The clearance was revoked following what were described as "vehement objections" from the military and from local political rivals in Marawi who claimed Ali was shielding the terrorists.<ref name="mindanews2022a" />

Ali spent several years in what he called a "safe sanctuary," unable to return to Marawi City, even as he continued to offer the government ideas on how to end the siege and begin the recovery.<ref name="oppap" /> For his supporters, this episode was a textbook case of state intelligence weaponized by local political rivalry.

Drug Accusations and Political Persecution

On top of the rebellion charges, Ali's name appeared in President Duterte's "narco-list" in August 2016. Government intelligence reports alleged that the drug trade in Lanao del Sur was controlled by the Ali and Salic brothers, including claims about the liquidation of rival drug operators.<ref name="politiko">Duterte drug matrix: Salic brothers control all drug trade in Lanao del Sur. Politiko. September 23, 2017. https://politiko.com.ph/2017/09/23/duterte-drug-matrix-salic-brothers-control-drug-trade-lanao-del-sur-sent-kill-orders-rival-drug-lords-dealers/</ref>

Ali's response was consistent and direct: he called the allegations the product of "dirty local politics," a coordinated effort to neutralize the Ali-Salic clan's electoral power. He pointed out that a man running a drug empire would not be living in the circumstances he lived in, and that the shabu allegedly recovered from his home during a raid had been planted by enemies.<ref name="mindanewsmain" />

He died in 2022 without ever having faced those charges in a courtroom, without ever having his day to answer formally or be formally cleared.

Counter-Extremism Work and Theological Moderation

Throughout the controversy and the years of living away from home, Omar Ali never stopped doing the one thing he considered his most important work: arguing against extremism in the Maranao language, in the Maranao voice, from a Maranao perspective.

For four years, he was the lead speaker on DXSR Radio Salam, a program funded through an OPAPP grant specifically designed to counter the spread of radical ideology in Lanao.<ref name="mindanews2022b" /> He also wrote and distributed a small book laying out practical strategies for communities to resist radicalization.<ref name="oppap" />

His theology was one of deliberate, studied moderation. He described himself as a "strong pillar of moderation in religion," a man who had spent decades studying what he called "Authentic Islam" and who could tell, chapter by verse, why the Maute group's ideology was a deviation from the Quran, not a fulfillment of it.<ref name="mindanews2022b" /> He once said plainly: if he had been the leader of Marawi City when the siege happened, he would have either talked the terrorists out or died fighting them. The destruction of his birthplace was, for him, the worst possible outcome, and one he had tried everything in his power to prevent.

Legacy

Omar Mohammad Solitario Ali passed away on April 8, 2022, in a hospital in Cagayan de Oro, from a brain tumor. He was in the middle of preparing for yet another run for the Marawi mayorship, still carrying the same vision he'd had since his days in the MNLF: a Marawi City that was modern, self-governing, morally grounded, and finally at peace.<ref name="inquirer">Former Marawi mayor Omar Ali passes away. Inquirer.net. 2022. https://newsinfo.inquirer.net/1580659/former-marawi-mayor-omar-ali-passes-away</ref>

Architect of Moral Governance

His two terms as mayor remain the most studied period of Marawi's civic history. The policies he put in place during 2001 to 2007 are now recognized as an early and locally developed model of what the BARMM has since formalized under the "Moral Governance" framework. He showed that Islamic ethics weren't incompatible with local government functions. They could be the foundation of them.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

Bridge Between Generations

Ali was one of the few leaders in the history of the Bangsamoro struggle who could genuinely speak to both the MNLF and the MILF, to the datus of the old sultanate and to the youth who knew him from the radio. His role in gathering MNLF and MILF leaders in 2015 to align their efforts toward the peace process is considered a turning point in Moro intra-group diplomacy.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

To the youth leaders and women's groups of Marawi, he was "Ama" (Father), a mentor who took the democratic process seriously even when it failed him, and who believed that self-determination had to be won through elections and institutions, not just through the barrel of a gun.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

The Legend of Solitario

He died carrying unresolved charges he believed were fabricated. His supporters call this a symbol of the "selective justice" that has defined the state's relationship with Moro leaders for generations. For them, the fact that he never had his day in court is not a footnote but a central part of his story: a man who served his people, served the government that distrusted him, stood against the extremists who wanted his city, and was never given a fair hearing for any of it.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />

His name, Solitario, carries its meaning into history: a leader who stood alone in his convictions, more often than not, but who never stopped standing.

Death

Omar Mohammad Solitario Ali passed away on **April 8, 2022**, in Cagayan de Oro City, Philippines, after a prolonged illness caused by a brain tumor. He had been living away from Marawi City for years due to the unresolved legal situation stemming from the 2017 siege, and his health had deteriorated during that period of displacement. He was reportedly in the process of filing his candidacy for the Marawi mayorship when he died, a final act that speaks to the kind of leader he was: still running, still believing, until the very end.<ref name="mindanewsmain" /><ref name="inquirer" />

Recognition

- Served as **Mayor of Marawi City** for two consecutive terms (2001–2007), among the longest sustained periods of reformist governance in the city's modern history.
- Acknowledged by Bangsamoro civic and political leaders as a **pioneer of Moral Governance** in local Muslim administration.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />
- Recognized as a **key architect of the 2015 MNLF-MILF unity effort** that contributed to the foundation of the BARMM peace framework.<ref name="mindanews2022b" />
- Honored posthumously by colleagues in the Moro peace movement as an **elder of the struggle** whose revolutionary legitimacy and theological moderation distinguished him from most of his contemporaries.

References

<references/>

Further Reading

- BANGSAMORO SPEAKS: On the Marawi Siege and the people unjustly implicated. MindaNews, April 2022.
- Omar Solitario Ali: "I cannot be and I will not be a terrorist." MindaNews, April 2022.
- VIOLENCE IN POLITICS AND THE POLITICS OF VIOLENCE: Understanding the Culture of Impunity in the ARMM. Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy.
- Islamic Leadership in BARMM, Philippines: Compatibility with Western Leadership and Effects on Organizational Performance. ResearchGate.
- The Philippines: Militancy and the New Bangsamoro. International Crisis Group.

See Also

- Marawi City
- Moro National Liberation Front
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Moral Governance
- Maranao people
- Maratabat
- 2017 Marawi Crisis
- Lanao del Sur
- Pat a Pangampong sa Ranao
- Nur Misuari
- 1976 Tripoli Agreement
- 1996 Final Peace Agreement
- Fahad Salic

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